Losers, Delegation, and the Ideological Valence of Expertise: Evidence from Finland

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Abstract

Research on partisan-motivated tolerance of democratic transgressions shows that voters often trade democratic procedures for partisan ends, weakening electoral checks on incumbents. Much less is known about how citizens evaluate delegation—shifting authority from elected politicians to unelected experts. We address this gap with a simple spatial voting model in which support for technocratic delegation trades off a perceived performance gain from experts against ideological loss relative to the governing coalition. The model yields two implications: (i) support for delegation declines monotonically with ideological distance from government when expert institutions are perceived as government-aligned; and (ii) this distance penalty attenuates when experts are perceived as more neutral or closer to voters than to the government. Empirically, we analyze a novel 2025 survey of Finnish adults—a high-capacity, multiparty parliamentary democracy and thus a hard case for partisan resistance to expertise. We develop an individual-level, seat-weighted measure of distance to the governing coalition based on party-closeness evaluations. Statistical models show that voters farther from the right-leaning Finnish cabinet are less supportive of delegation; results replicate with different measurements. Substantively, losers' consent to technocracy is conditional: delegation is acceptable primarily when performance gains outweigh ideological costs and when expert bodies are not seen as aligned with incumbents.

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1 Electoral Losers and Experts: A Marriage of Convenience?

Democracy rarely dies to the sound of tanks (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018); they might also fade behind legalese, "independent commissions," and "crisis cabinets" staffed by experts (Levitsky and Way 2002). In Finland, the COVID-19 pandemic made this trade-off vivid: trust in public health authorities and scientific advisers was high on average, yet a subset of voters—disproportionately out-partisans—grew skeptical when expert guidance arrived alongside the government's agenda. Other notable examples are when, in polarized electorates, citizens often swallow anti-liberal moves when their side benefits (Svolik 2020; Svolik 2019). Classic work links electoral competition and cleavage structure to regime vulnerability (Sartori 1976; Dahl 1971; Lipset 1981), while contemporary research shows how incumbents tilt the field without canceling elections (Levitsky and Way 2010; Bermeo 2016; Waldner and Lust 2018). Our paper pushes this literature one step earlier in the causal chain and asks: *when do voters prefer the steady hand of "experts" over the rough justice of elections?* While oppositions often support strengthening checks as political insurance against executive overreach (Capoccia 2007), our claim is narrower: a *subset* of voters resists technocratic delegation when expert bodies are perceived as government-aligned. This scope condition shifts the focus from aggregate trust in experts to partisan perceptions of alignment, explaining why technocratic delegation polarizes electoral losers.

Our contribution is twofold. Theoretically, we develop a simple formal model in which voters weigh a performance advantage from technocratic rule against ideological loss; the model predicts that support for technocratic delegation falls with ideological distance from the governing bloc when experts are perceived as government-aligned. Empirically, we analyze a new 2025 survey of adults in Finland—a high-capacity, multiparty parliamentary democracy and thus a hard case where expert governance might otherwise be broadly acceptable (OECD 2021). Even in this consensual, high-trust context, support for democratic norms is conditional (Saarinen, Koivula, and Keipi 2020). For example, Saikkonen and Christensen (2023) find that a subset of voters tolerates transgressions by ideologically congruent leaders, while disaffected citizens sanction less. Related Finnish evidence shows that support for technocratic decision-making concentrates among respondents who view "ordinary citizens" as less competent, whereas confidence in fellow citizens tilts preferences toward representative or participatory channels (Rapeli and Von Schoultz 2023). Our paper recenters the debate about backsliding on a neglected choice: not just whether citizens punish rule-breaking (*à la* Svolik 2020; Svolik 2019), but whether they are willing to *outsource* rule-making to experts in the first place. Ultimately, our approach bridges elite-centric accounts of backsliding, which stress supply and cueing (Bartels 2023), with demand-side realism about voter cognition (Achen and Bartels 2016). We study a concrete instantiation of the broader tension between popular sovereignty and liberal constraints (Mounk 2018): when do citizens prefer delegation to unelected experts over electoral accountability?

Our core claim is that technocratic delegation is ideologically valenced: when expert bodies are seen as aligned with incumbents, electoral losers are less willing to shift authority away from elected politicians. In doing so, we foreground ideological heterogeneity regarding expert delegation within losers' consent—a dimension that has received relatively little systematic attention. We formalize this intuition with a simple voter-choice model in which individuals compare the expected performance advantage from technocratic rule to the ideological loss from ceding control. The model yields two testable implications that guide our empirics. First, when expert bodies are perceived as aligned with the government, support for delegation declines steadily as a voter's ideological distance from the incumbent grows. Voters back delegation only when the expected performance gains from expertise outweigh the policy mismatch they anticipate. Second, this distance penalty weakens when experts are viewed as neutral—or closer to the voter than to the government—and

becomes steeper when experts are seen as tightly aligned with incumbents.

Our account complements two adjacent perspectives. First, when citizens perceive an ideologically congruent and competent executive, they may endorse reallocating authority in ways that weaken checks because expected policy gains loom large—what Singer (2018) calls the "pernicious effects" of good representation and performance on tolerance for constraining rival actors. Second, recent work argues that democratic stability depends not only on losers' consent but also on *winners' restraint*, i.e., the willingness of outcome winners to withdraw legitimacy when procedures are violated; crucially, such restraint is activated as violations accumulate rather than immediately (Werner, Bertsou, and Marien 2025). Our focus is on the losers' side of this equilibrium: when expert bodies are *perceived* as aligned with incumbents, distance from government translates into lower willingness to delegate.

The paper also finds empirical support for our theoretical expectations. We exploit a novel survey of adults in Finland. Respondents reported closeness to each parliamentary party; these evaluations were combined into a respondent-level proximity to the governing coalition by weighting coalition parties by their parliamentary seat shares and renormalizing weights over the parties each respondent rated. The proximity measure was transformed into a normalized distance-to-government index. Consistent with the model's first implication, results show a clear negative association between distance from the governing coalition and support for expert delegation. In line with the second implication, the relationship weakens when expert bodies are perceived as less ideologically aligned and strengthens among respondents with stronger partisan attachments. The pattern is robust to alternative distance constructions and to modeling choices. Taken together, the formal model clarifies the mechanism-delegation is acceptable only when the perceived performance advantage exceeds the ideological loss—and the evidence aligns with this logic: in Finland, support for delegation is lowest among voters distant from the governing coalition when expert authority is perceived as aligned with the incumbents.

Finland is a demanding case for our argument. It is a high-capacity, consensus-oriented polity where trust in public institutions and expertise is generally high. Precisely for that reason, it helps isolate heterogeneities in how citizens evaluate delegation, potentially increasing the inferential leverage of our findings. Our claim is not that Finns view experts as partisan in the aggregate, but that a *subset of voters*—especially those far from the governing coalition—infer alignment when expert bodies advise, are appointed by, or implement the agenda of incumbents. Anecdotal evidence from the COVID-19 period illustrates this pattern: despite high average trust, confidence in official expert guidance varied by party sympathy, with skepticism concentrated among out-partisans while co-partisans remained supportive. In our framework, such heterogeneities matter because these voters evaluate delegation as a trade-off: a perceived governance-quality gain versus an ideological loss. The formal model makes this mechanism explicit and yields the core prediction we test: even in a high-trust environment, support for delegation declines with ideological distance from government when experts are perceived as government-aligned and the effect attenuates when experts are seen as neutral. Overall, we find that the observed pattern is driven by a subset of voters rather than by generalized anti-expert sentiment. Finally, our question sits at the intersection of realist views of mass politics (Achen and Bartels 2016) and critiques of the administrative/technocratic state (Hamburger 2014; Glennon 2014; Majone 1994): when, and for which subset of voters, is delegating authority to unelected experts preferred to decision-making by elected politicians—especially when experts are perceived as aligned with the incumbent coalition?

2 When Expertise Is Perceived as Partisan

Democratic governance typically balances technocratic delegation against democratic accountability. Technocratic delegation refers to entrusting policy authority to experts or non-partisan institutions insulated from direct electoral control. Examples include independent central banks, regulatory agencies, or constitutional courts staffed by specialists. Such delegation is justified by the promise of neutral competence and long-term policy stability, but it inherently trades off responsiveness to the electorate. In other words, empowering the experts may improve technocratic quality at the cost of reducing the public's direct say in decision-making (Caramani 2017). This tension is well documented: technocratic policy-making can dilute traditional accountability, since decisions occur outside the arena of partisan competition and popular oversight (Bertsou and Caramani 2020). Democratic accountability, by contrast, requires that those who make policy are answerable to voters through elections and representative institutions. The crux of the issue is that what incumbents defend as neutral expertise, electoral losers may perceive as unaccountable elite rule.

Institutional independence need not equal neutrality. Preferences for delegation also vary along non-ideological lines: attitudes toward technocracy track beliefs about mass competence, helping explain why a subset of voters accepts expert rule even in high-trust contexts (Rapeli and Von Schoultz 2023). Performance and felt representation can legitimate authority shifts that sideline rivals (Singer 2018), whereas winners' vigilance tends to activate only as procedural violations accumulate (Werner, Bertsou, and Marien 2025). Consequently, losers read delegation through a partisan lens, while winners' support is conditional and violation-sensitive. Even insulated bodies can be "independent but not indifferent." For example, in the U.S., the Federal Reserve has behaved as a "conditional inflation hawk," at times advantaging one partisan bloc (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013). The implication for our theory is direct: losers' consent to delegation hinges on whether ostensibly neutral institutions are perceived as impartial or aligned; although oppositions often back checks as insurance against executive power (Capoccia 2007), a subset of voters resists technocratic delegation when expert bodies are seen as government-aligned—even as they continue to endorse judicial or oversight constraints.

Losers' consent is central to democratic stability: those who lose must still accept the system and expect protection in opposition (Anderson et al. 2005). Acceptance is easier when independent institutions credibly guard fair play. When these bodies are perceived as partisan—stacked with or sympathetic to incumbents—consent to delegation collapses. Technocratic delegation then looks like a democratic end-run: unelected actors advancing the winners' program. Accordingly, losers resist ceding authority to such bodies, invoking accountability and the "will of the people."

Our argument draws on several strands of research. In polarized polities, even nominally non-partisan institutions are viewed through partisan lenses. Polarization—the deep ideological divide between camps—erodes a shared baseline of institutional trust. Svolik (2019) shows that intense polarization "undermines the public's ability to serve as a democratic check": voters trade democratic principles for partisan gains. As a result, each side suspects that ostensibly neutral referees (judiciary, civil service, expert regulators) tilt toward the other camp. Empirically, support for liberal-democratic checks is increasingly sorted by partisanship: in countries governed by right-populist parties (Hungary, Poland, Brazil), government supporters express lower support for constraints, whereas opponents value them more (Claassen et al. 2025). The upshot is mirror-image perceptions—*winners discount constraints, losers champion them, unless they believe the institutions are captured.* Under hyper-polarization, bodies meant to serve as neutral checks become, or are seen as, instruments of incumbent advantage; polarization thereby "magnifies the partisan capture of independent institutions," corroding their legitimacy (Lieberman et al. 2019, p. 471).

Given this dynamic, electoral losers are most likely to oppose technocratic delegation when expert

bodies carry ideological valence aligned with incumbents. By ideological valence we mean that expert institutions are *perceived* not as neutral but as tilting toward one side of the spectrum. Expertise is never exercised in a vacuum: economic technocrats may hew to market-liberal orthodoxy (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013; Clark, S. Golder, and Poast 2013); legal–bureaucratic elites may share the regime's social outlook; scientific experts may prioritize values of one cultural camp. In polarized contexts, these associations become salient. Losers, then can come to view the "independent" central bank as effectively partisan (e.g., austerity that aligns with the government) or the judiciary as stacked with loyalists. What looks like a technocratic decision—an impartial public-health directive or a monetary tightening—is then read through a partisan lens. Perceived bias short-circuits trust: delegation appears less like neutral expertise and more like entrenchment behind a facade of objectivity.

Partisans also apply a double standard to ostensibly "neutral" oversight: support for checks is strongest when they restrain the out-party and softens when they bind co-partisans (Svolik 2019; Kingzette et al. 2021). This aligns with the realist view that group identity and performance, not abstract proceduralism, structure mass attitudes (Achen and Bartels 2016). Thus, both winners and losers champion checks when useful and discount them when costly. An out-party's demand for accountability can therefore mask outcome concerns: "unelected bureaucrats" or "activist judges" draw fire when they are perceived as aligned with the rival camp. Our argument links this demand-side asymmetry to backsliding: just as incumbents may erode checks to entrench power, oppositions may withdraw support from institutions they deem compromised, making commitment to rules contingent on who controls state authority (Waldner and Lust 2018).

Opposition to technocratic delegation should be most acute under two conditions. First, when polarization and partisan identity are strong: mutual mistrust is high, and even independent institutions are painted red or blue; compromise outside electoral contest is treated as loss. Under such polarization, the baseline for losers' consent—confidence that the system treats sides fairly—erodes. Second, when incumbents have politicized or captured nominally technocratic bodies. Governments often use appointments or institutional reforms to bias independent agencies during backsliding episodes (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019)—packing courts, tilting election commissions, staffing central-bank boards with ideologues. These moves become focal points for conflict; oppositions then resist further empowerment of those bodies, sometimes refusing to recognize captured referees. Where integrity is compromised, losers predictably reject delegation.

Crucially, our theory does not claim that electoral losers oppose expert rule *per se*. Support for delegation is conditional on perceived neutrality relative to partisan competition. Where expert institutions enjoy cross-partisan trust, losers may willingly delegate—indeed, oppositions have historically strengthened independent authorities to constrain executives (Keefer and Stasavage 2003). Likewise, citizens alienated from partisan politics ("structural losers") sometimes prefer technocratic governance over dysfunctional party competition (Bertsou and Caramani 2020). These scenarios presume a separation between expertise and ideology. When that presumption fails—when expertise is perceived as aligned—delegation is no longer a neutral fix but a way to lock in the ruling coalition's program. In such cases, losers frame technocratic delegation as illegitimate and call to return decisions to "the people" via elections or referendums.

This logic yields clear implications. Losers' resistance to delegation should intensify in highly polarized, ideologically sorted systems and during periods of sharp government–opposition conflict. It also helps explain why populist movements—often composed of recent electoral or globalization losers—target technocratic institutions as part of a corrupt establishment (Caramani 2017). Conversely, in consensus-oriented or depolarized settings, or where technocratic bodies retain cross-partisan legitimacy, backlash should be weaker. The broader paradox follows: institutions designed as impartial checks sustain stability only if they are *seen* as impartial. Once viewed as instruments

of those in power, the very actors who must accept them—the electoral losers—may withdraw consent, straining the balance between expertise and democracy.

3 A Voter's Trade-Off: Performance vs. Ideological Distance

Consider a one-dimensional policy space $[0, 1]$. A voter i has ideal point $\theta_i \in [0, 1]$. The governing coalition ("government") has position $\theta_g \in [0, 1]$. A technocratic institution ("experts") has perceived position $\theta_e \in [0, 1]$.

Distance and alignment. Define voter–government distance

$$d_i \;\equiv\; |\theta_i - \theta_g| \in [0, 1],$$

which corresponds to our empirical measure `Government distance`. Perceived expert *alignment* with government is summarized by $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ via

$$\theta_e(\alpha) \;=\; \alpha\,\theta_g + (1 - \alpha)\,\bar{\theta},$$

where $\bar{\theta}$ is a non–partisan reference (e.g., a technocratic consensus or the median policy). Full alignment means $\alpha = 1$ (so $\theta_e = \theta_g$); lower α implies more neutral experts.

Sequence. Voter i chooses between retaining the status quo of elected–politician control (S) or *delegating* to experts (D). Under D, policy is set at $\theta_e(\alpha)$

Preferences. Utility is spatial with a perceived technocratic performance/competence gain $B \geq 0$:

$$U_i(S) = -(\theta_i - \theta_S)^2, \tag{1}$$

$$U_i(D) = -(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha))^2 \;+\; B(\alpha). \tag{2}$$

Here B captures the expected advantage from expert rule (information, insulation from short-termism, etc.) and $B'(\alpha) < 0$. There is *no* additional penalty term.

Decision rule. Voter i supports delegation iff $U_i(D) > U_i(S)$, i.e.

$$\begin{cases} \theta_i > \theta_i^\star(\alpha) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) > \theta_S \\ \theta_i < \theta_i^\star(\alpha) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) < \theta_S \end{cases}$$

where,

$$\theta_i^\star(\alpha) \;\equiv\; \frac{\theta_e(\alpha) + \theta_S}{2} - \frac{B(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)},$$

Therefore, D is chosen iff

$$\begin{cases} 1/2 > F(\theta_i^\star(\alpha)) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) > \theta_S \\ 1/2 < F(\theta_i^\star(\alpha)) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) < \theta_S \end{cases}$$

Note that the indifferent voter depends on α, which captures the alignment between the government and the experts. That is,

$$\frac{\partial \theta_i^\star(\alpha)}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\theta_e'(\alpha)}{2}\Big(1 + \frac{B(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)^2}\Big) + \frac{B'(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)} \tag{3}$$

The derivative consists of two forces:

- Ideological alignment channel.The term:

$$\frac{\theta_e'(\alpha)}{2}\Big(1 + \frac{B(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)^2}\Big)$$

  captures how the policy implemented by experts shifts as alignment increases. A higher α makes the experts' policy more similar to the government's preferred alternative. As a consequence, the delegated policy moves away from the status quo and becomes more extreme from the voters' perspective. This displacement pushes the indifferent voter in the direction of θ_g, if $\theta_g > \bar{\theta}$, the indifferent voter shifts to the right; if $\theta_g < \bar{\theta}$, it shifts to the left. In other words, stronger alignment increases the ideological distance between the delegated policy and moderate voters, thereby reducing support for delegation.

- Efficiency channel. The second term,

$$\frac{B'(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)}$$

  reflects the fact that higher alignment reduces the benefits of delegation, since $B'(\alpha) < 0$ by assumption. The effect of this efficiency loss is conditional on the ideological position of the delegated policy relative to the status quo. When the experts' policy lies to the right of the status quo ($\theta_e(\alpha) > \theta_S$), deteriorating efficiency pushes the indifferent voter to the right and therefore lowers support for delegation. In contrast, when the experts' policy lies to the left of the status quo ($\theta_e(\alpha) < \theta_S$), the same reduction in efficiency shifts the indifferent voter to the left and increases support for delegation. Intuitively, efficiency losses matter more when they exacerbate the ideological divergence with respect to the status quo.

Note that the effect of a marginal increase in alignment α on the position of the indifferent voter is a priori ambiguous. The direction of this effect depends on the relative strength of two opposing mechanisms.

On the one hand, the efficiency channel captures how delegation increases the likelihood that policies are closer to voters' ideal points due to the expert's superior competence. This channel pushes the indifferent voter to favor delegation as alignment increases.

On the other hand, the ideological channel reflects how greater alignment shifts the expected policy outcome toward the expert's preferred alternative. This channel can move the indifferent voter away from delegation when the expert's ideal point is sufficiently distant.

Thus, the net effect of alignment on support for delegation depends on the interplay between these two channels, making the sign of the comparative static generally ambiguous.

Comparative Statics

The effect of increased alignment α on public support for delegation is *a priori* ambiguous, since it operates through two opposing mechanisms. First, the *efficiency channel* lowers $\theta_i^\star(\alpha)$, reflecting that better-aligned experts reduce the expected bias cost of delegation. Second, the *ideological channel* raises $\theta_i^\star(\alpha)$, because higher alignment moves the delegated policy closer to the government's preferred position and thus farther from the status quo. The overall effect depends on which of these forces dominates.

To characterize how support for delegation responds to alignment, recall that delegation is chosen if:

$$\begin{cases} 1/2 > F(\theta_i^\star(\alpha)) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) > \theta_S, \\ 1/2 < F(\theta_i^\star(\alpha)) & \text{if } \theta_e(\alpha) < \theta_S, \end{cases}$$

where

$$\theta_i^\star(\alpha) \equiv \frac{\theta_e(\alpha) + \theta_S}{2} - \frac{B(\alpha)}{2(\theta_e(\alpha) - \theta_S)}.$$

When the expert is located to the right of the status quo ($\theta_e(\alpha) > \theta_S$), delegation gains support whenever $\theta_i^\star(\alpha)$ decreases, since more voters satisfy $\theta_i > \theta_i^\star(\alpha)$. Hence, an increase in alignment raises support for delegation if and only if the efficiency channel dominates the ideological channel, leading to $\frac{d\theta_i^\star}{d\alpha} < 0$. Conversely, if $\frac{d\theta_i^\star}{d\alpha} > 0$, alignment reduces support.

The logic reverses when the expert is located to the left of the status quo ($\theta_e(\alpha) < \theta_S$). In this case, delegation is chosen when $\theta_i < \theta_i^\star(\alpha)$, so a higher cutoff expands support. Thus, alignment increases support for delegation if and only if $\frac{d\theta_i^\star}{d\alpha} > 0$; if $\frac{d\theta_i^\star}{d\alpha} < 0$, alignment contracts support.

Taken together, these results imply that the effect of alignment on support for delegation is shaped by both the location of the expert relative to the status quo and the relative strength of efficiency gains versus ideological drift. Alignment promotes delegation when it sufficiently reduces expected bias relative to the ideological cost of empowering more loyal experts, and undermines delegation otherwise.

Propositions.

1. **Losers oppose aligned technocracy.** If $\alpha = 1$, there exists a cutoff $d_i^\star(B) = \sqrt{B}$ such that voter i supports delegation iff $d_i < d_i^\star$. Thus, for any fixed $B > 0$, support for delegation is strictly decreasing in d_i.

2. **Neutral experts attenuate the distance penalty.** If $\alpha < 1$ and $\bar{\theta}$ is closer to θ_i than θ_g is, then $L_i(\alpha) < d_i^2$, so the required valence $B_i^\star(\alpha)$ falls relative to the aligned case. Opposition voters may accept delegation when experts are perceived neutral, holding B fixed.

Link to identification **??** delivers the empirical prediction that, when expert institutions are perceived as government–aligned, *support for delegation is decreasing in the normalized distance* d_i and increasing in perceived valence B, with attenuation when experts are viewed as more neutral ($\alpha < 1$). This maps to our econometric specification with `Government distance` as the main covariate and measures of institutional trust/competence as proxies for (B, α).

4 Data and Findings

The data comes from an original survey conducted in Finland ($n = 1516$), with statistical quotas applied for age, gender and region of residence.[0]

4.1 Measurement

The main independent variable is `Government distance`, a respondent–government distance measure based on party–closeness ratings.

Let i index respondents and let $p \in G$ index parties in the governing coalition. Survey respondents rated their closeness to each parliamentary party on a 0–10 scale. Let $C_{ip} \in [0, 10]$ denote respondent i's closeness to party p. Let s_p be party p's seat count in the *Eduskunta* (the Finnish Parliament) at the time of fieldwork,[1] and define coalition seat weights

$$w_p \equiv \frac{s_p}{\sum_{q \in G} s_q}. \tag{4}$$

Due to missingness, weights were renormalized over the set of parties that respondent i rated:

$$\tilde{w}_{ip} \equiv \frac{w_p \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{ip} \text{ observed}\}}{\sum_{q \in G} w_q \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{iq} \text{ observed}\}}. \tag{5}$$

Then, seat–weighted coalition closeness is

$$\texttt{Government closeness}_i \equiv \sum_{p \in G} \tilde{w}_{ip} \, C_{ip} \;\in\; [0, 10]. \tag{6}$$

We scaled it to $[0, 1]$ and defined the complementary distance index:

$$\texttt{Government distance}_i \equiv 1 - \frac{\texttt{Government closeness}_i}{10} \;\in\; [0, 1]. \tag{7}$$

By construction, larger $\texttt{Government distance}_i$ indicates greater distance from the governing coalition.

Beyond the seat–weighted baseline in Equation 7, we also construct two conceptually adjacent indices. First, an *unweighted* coalition proximity treats each governing party symmetrically, abstracting from parliamentary strength and thereby reducing dependence on the specific seat distribution at fieldwork. Let

$$\texttt{Government closeness (UW)}_i \;\equiv\; \frac{\sum_{p \in G} C_{ip} \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{ip} \text{ observed}\}}{\sum_{q \in G} \mathbb{1}\{C_{iq} \text{ observed}\}} \;\in\; [0, 10], \tag{A1}$$

with `NA` if no governing party was rated. The associated distance is

$$\texttt{Government distance (UW)}_i \;\equiv\; 1 - \frac{\texttt{Government closeness (UW)}_i}{10} \;\in\; [0, 1]. \tag{8}$$

Second, a *closest–party* distance captures the heuristic that respondents may anchor evaluations on the single governing party they feel closest to (salience of a primary partisan tie), and it is maximally robust to selective answering:

[0] Data collection took place between January and February 2025 through an online panel recruited by Qualtrics.

[1] KOK = 48, PS = 46, RKP = 9, KD = 5.

$$\texttt{Government distance (Closest)}_i \equiv 1 - \frac{\max_{p \in G} C_{ip}}{10} \in [0,1], \tag{9}$$

set to `NA` when all C_{ip} for $p \in G$ are missing.

Taken together, the seat–weighted (Equation 7), unweighted (Equation 8), and closest–party (Equation 9) indices map, respectively, to influence–weighted proximity to the governing bloc, an equal–party aggregation, and a strongest–affinity anchor. We use all three in the empirical analysis; as shown below, they yield substantively similar patterns, indicating that our results do not hinge on a particular distance construction or on the treatment of item nonresponse.

4.2 Estimation Strategy

We estimated the association between support for technocratic delegation (`Technocracy`) and ideological distance from the governing coalition (`Government distance`) using a linear specification. Now, let $\texttt{Technocracy}_i$ denote respondent i's technocracy item and $\texttt{Government distance}_i$ the normalized index in Equation 7.[2]

For expositional clarity we use the seat–weighted index as our primary measure, since it mirrors parties' relative bargaining power within the cabinet and thus the theoretical object of interest—proximity to the governing bloc as policy setter. It also tempers noise from idiosyncratic ratings of very small coalition partners with limited agenda influence. For robustness, we re–estimate all models with the unweighted aggregation (Equation 8) and the closest–party anchor (Equation 9); the results are substantively unchanged (Table A1). The baseline model is

$$\begin{aligned}\texttt{Technocracy}_i = \beta_0 & \\ & + \beta_1 \texttt{Government distance}_i \\ & + \beta_2 \texttt{Democratic satisfaction}_i \\ & + \beta_3 \texttt{Trust in politicians}_i \\ & + \boldsymbol{\gamma}' \mathbf{X}_i \\ & + \delta_{\text{region}(i)} \\ & + \varepsilon_i\end{aligned} \tag{10}$$

where $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes education, age, and gender, and $\delta_{\text{region}(i)}$ are region fixed effects. The coefficient of interest is β_1, which—under the formal model's assumptions—should be negative when expert institutions are perceived as aligned with the incumbent bloc.

4.3 Results

Figure 1 plots marginal-standardized (average) predictions of expert support across the full range of distance from the current Finnish Government.[3] Effects are modest but meaningful in a hard case like Finland. Across all three panels—seat-weighted, unweighted, and closest-party—the relationship is monotonically negative: moving from full proximity to maximal distance from the Government

[2]We treated the 1–5 outcome variable as approximately continuous (ordered models are reported as robustness in Table A2, yielding substantively identical conclusions). The survey question asked (originally in Finnish) "What do you think about the following statements? [...] Our country would work better if political decisions were left to independent, non-elected experts instead of politicians." The options were "Strongly disagree" (n=133), "Somewhat disagree" (n=248), "Neither agree nor disagree" (n=383), "Somewhat agree" (n=436) and "Totally agree" (n=197).

[3]The solid line is the point estimate and the band the 95% CI.

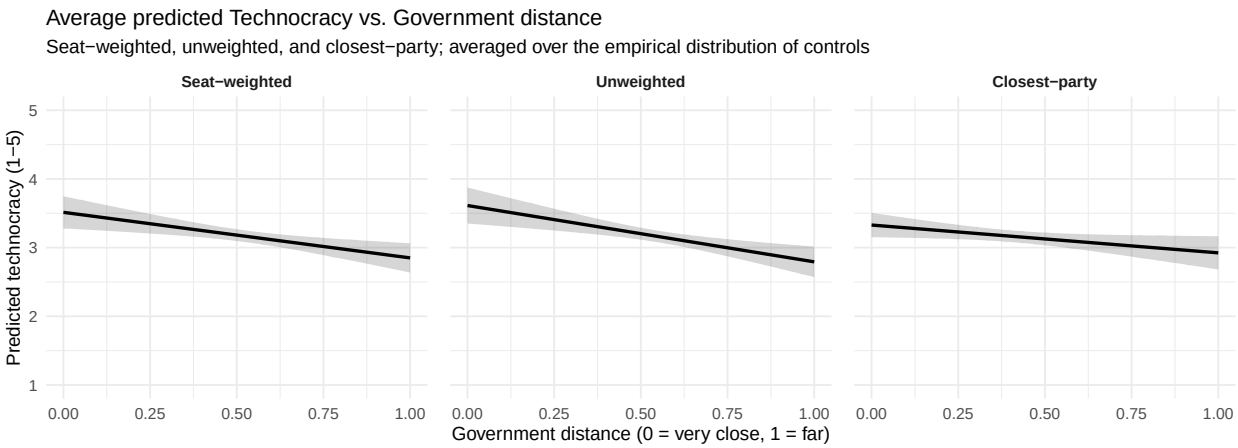

Figure 1: Average predicted: technocracy vs. government distance (95% CIs).

lowered the predicted score from roughly 3.5 to about 2.8 on the 1-5 scale. The near-identical slope in the unweighted panel shows that the pattern did not hinge on coalition seat shares or renormalization, while the closest-party panel reproduced the same decline.

In light of our voter-choice framework, these estimates are consistent with a mechanism in which ideological loss rises with distance while the perceived performance gain B is held fixed. As distance widens, $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$ increases, so fewer respondents clear the delegation threshold $B > (\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$. Substantively, the slope moves the average respondent from slight technocratic sympathy toward skepticism as distance increases.

Although the survey did not directly ask whether experts were perceived as ideologically biased, the gradient in Figure 1 is unlikely to be an artifact of measurement or data aggregation, suggesting that experts were not viewed as uniformly neutral. The pattern implies that a nontrivial share of respondents inferred some alignment between expert bodies and the right-leaning cabinet, which depressed willingness to delegate among those farthest from the government in ideological space. At the same time, these results do not suggest that Finnish voters, on average, saw experts as politicized. We believe that Finland's high baseline of institutional trust coexists with different heterogeneity levels: a considerable number of respondents likely trusted experts, while others—disproportionately opposition-aligned voters—appeared more sensitive to who would be empowered and who appointed them.

The near-parallel slopes across the seat-weighted, unweighted, and closest-party panels, together with ordered-logit estimates that treat the outcome as ordinal (Table A2), indicate that the core association is not an artifact of proximity aggregation or outcome scaling.

Perceived Government-Expert Alignment Because we do not directly observe whether respondents think expert bodies are aligned with the government, we proxy perceived alignment with a relative trust differential between the cabinet and a flagship expert institution (the Bank of Finland). The logic is comparative: if a respondent trusts the cabinet more than the Central Bank, she is more likely to infer that expert agencies will follow the government's lead; if she trusts the Central Bank more, she is more likely to view experts as independent. This rests on a reasonable behavioral assumption: cabinets appoint senior agency officials, set mandates, control budgets, and, during salient episodes, coordinate messaging with agencies through joint briefings. We assume that relative trust therefore serves as a practical cue for who effectively holds influence and control. Higher trust in the cabinet implies that these tools of control will matter, so respondents expect

experts to align with the government's program when preferences diverge. Higher trust in the Bank of Finland suggests statutory insulation, professional norms, and reputational constraints that sustain autonomy. For example, after a cabinet announces a new policy priority alongside the agency it just staffed, respondents who trust the cabinet more will expect the agency to carry out that program; respondents who trust the Bank of Finland more will expect the appointee to follow established standards even if ministers prefer otherwise. In short, the trust gap is a simple proxy for perceived government-expert alignment.

Formally, let T_i^G denote trust in the current government (0–10) and T_i^E trust in the central bank. Define the signed gap

$$\texttt{Align}_i \equiv T_i^G - T_i^E.$$

For exposition we map this to the unit interval and, for estimation, center it at the indifference point:

$$\texttt{Align}_i^{01} \in [0,1], \qquad \texttt{Align}_{i,c}^{01} \equiv \texttt{Align}_i^{01} - 0.5 \in [-0.5, 0.5].$$

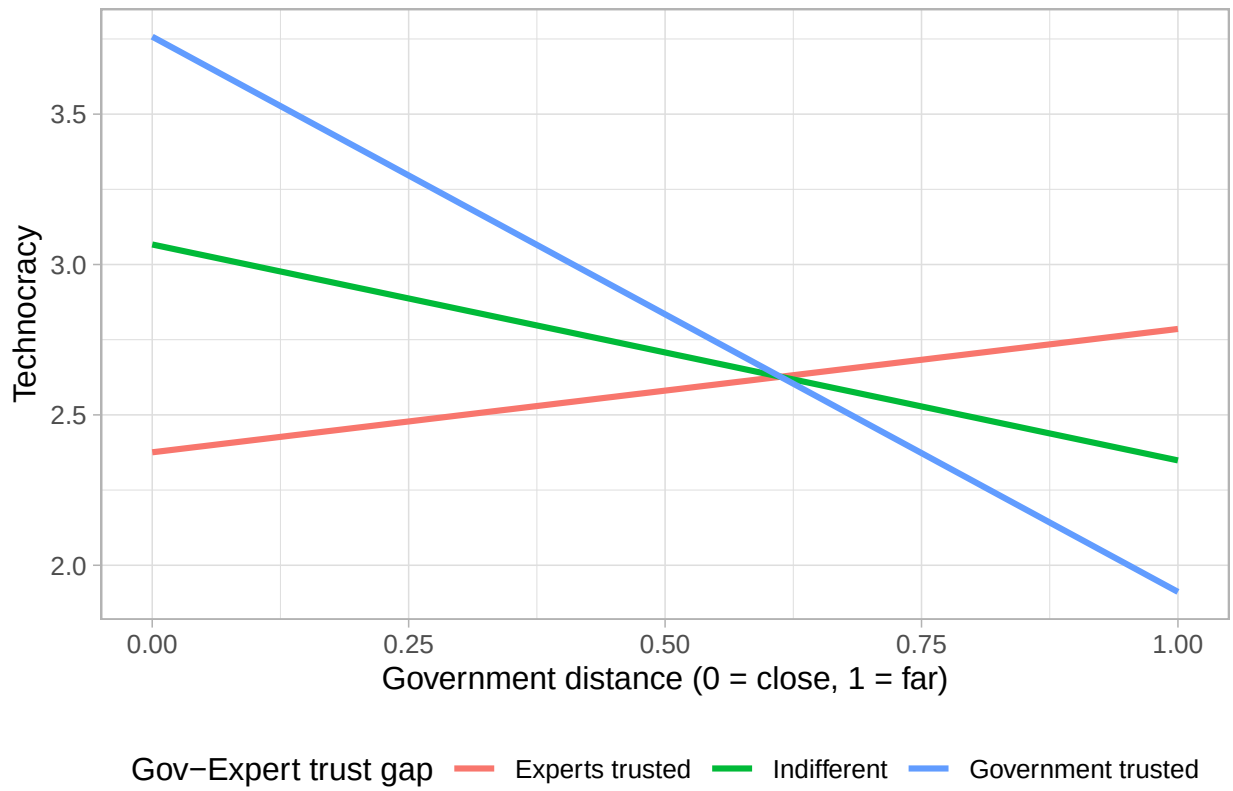

Figure 2: Interactive OLS hypothesis: Technocracy × Government distance moderated by Gov-Expert trust gap

By construction, $\texttt{Align}_{i,c}^{01} = 0$ indicates indifference ($T_i^G \approx T_i^E$); positive values indicate a government-over-experts premium ($T_i^G > T_i^E$), and negative values indicate an experts-over-government premium ($T_i^E > T_i^G$). Using the gap rather than the levels T_i^G and T_i^E reduces sensitivity to response-style shifts (e.g., $(8,7)$ and $(2,1)$ imply the same comparative orientation),

focuses the interaction on *perceived alignment* rather than absolute institutional trust, and makes the main-distance slope β_1 interpretable exactly at indifference ($\texttt{Align}^{01}_{i,c} = 0$).

We estimate

$$\begin{aligned}
\texttt{Technocracy}_i \; &= \beta_0 \\
&+ \; \beta_1 \, \texttt{Government distance}_i \\
&+ \; \beta_2 \, \texttt{Align}^{01}_{i,c} \\
&+ \; \beta_3 \left(\texttt{Government distance}_i \times \texttt{Align}^{01}_{i,c} \right) \\
&+ \; \boldsymbol{\gamma}' \, \mathbf{X}_i \\
&+ \; \delta_{\text{region}(i)} \\
&+ \; \varepsilon_i \, ,
\end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

and plot marginal predictions at $\texttt{Align}^{01}_{i,c} \in \{-0.25,\, 0,\, +0.25\}$, labeled in the legend as "Experts trusted" (negative gap), "Indifferent" (0), and "Government trusted" (positive gap).

Figure 2 displays the expected pattern.[4] When government is trusted over experts ("Government trusted"; positive gap), the slope of technocratic support with respect to government distance is clearly *negative*: moving away from the governing bloc lowers predicted support for delegation. Around indifference (gap ≈ 0), the negative slope attenuates. When experts are trusted over government ("Experts trusted"; negative gap), the line is flat to mildly *positive*, consistent with greater willingness to delegate when experts are perceived as independent.

5 Discussion and Limitations

This study argued that citizens evaluated technocratic delegation through an ideologically valenced lens. We formalized a voter's choice as a trade-off between a perceived performance gain from expert rule, the ideological loss from ceding authority to actors aligned with the incumbent coalition. The model yielded two central implications: support for delegation decreased with ideological distance from government when experts were perceived as aligned and this distance penalty attenuated when experts were viewed as neutral. Empirically, we analyzed a novel Finnish survey and constructed respondent-level distances to the governing coalition using seat-weighted party-closeness, alongside unweighted and closest-party variants. Linear and ordered-logit models consistently indicated a monotonic, negative association between distance and support for delegation. Average predicted values declined across the full distance range and the pattern replicated under alternative distance constructions, supporting the model's core comparative statics.

The findings were especially noteworthy because Finland constituted a demanding case. Finland reliably ranked very high on institutional trust, and large shares of the public trusted government, civil service, and the broader expert community. In such a context, technocratic delegation would have been expected to be broadly acceptable across partisan lines. Instead, support appeared conditional on perceived alignment: voters ideologically distant from the right-leaning cabinet expressed lower willingness to delegate. This pattern was consistent with the idea that, even in a high-trust polity, a nontrivial segment of the electorate inferred that experts could lean toward the incumbents, thereby activating a partisan calculus. At the same time, the results did not imply

[4] We follow Brambor, Clark, and M. Golder (2006, p. 73) and interpret the interaction via marginal effects rather than coefficient signs in the table.

that all Finns viewed experts as politicized. Taken together, we find that technocratic delegation was endorsed when the performance gains outweighed ideological losses.

These results come with several caveats. First, although we now operationalize perceived alignment with a trust differential (government-over-experts trust gap), this remains a proxy rather than a direct measure of whether respondents *believe* experts are government-aligned. The interaction between `Government distance` and the gap behaves as the theory predicts—strongly negative when $T_i^G > T_i^E$, attenuated near $T_i^G \approx T_i^E$, and weak/flat when $T_i^G < T_i^E$—which provides construct validity, but the gap could also absorb generalized regime affect or performance evaluations. Second, the design is observational and cross–sectional, so distance and the trust gap may be jointly shaped by latent ideology or anti–elitism; causal claims should therefore be cautious. Future work should field direct items on perceived capture/appointment trust and agency ideology, and deploy experiments that randomize appointment rules, explicit ideological cues, and performance signals, ideally embedded in panels around salient appointments or cabinet reshuffles.

Third, our distance measure relied on self-reported party-closeness and seat-share weights as a proxy for influence within the cabinet. Nonresponse patterns and measurement error in closeness ratings could introduce noise, and seat weights might imperfectly map onto perceived agenda power. We partially addressed this by reporting unweighted and closest-party variants, which delivered substantively similar results, but additional weighting schemes should be explored in future research. Fourth, the technocracy outcome was a single ordered item. Although results were robust to ordered-logit specifications, single-item measures are vulnerable to wording effects or scale interpretation.

Fifth, while Finland served as a strong hard test, external validity beyond high-trust, consensus-oriented democracies remained uncertain. The same mechanism could be stronger where baseline trust was lower and polarization higher, but it could also interact with other macro-level variables. Finally, our analyses focused on attitudes; thus, behavioral implications remained to be established.

Several extensions follow. First, future surveys should directly measure perceived expert alignment and credibility of appointment procedures (e.g., transparent vs. partisan selection). Experimental vignettes could randomize expert appointment rules, explicit ideological signals, and evidence of performance, allowing a clean test of the model's thresholds. Second, designs that exploit temporal variation—before/after cabinet reshuffles, high-salience appointments, or prominent policy episodes—would sharpen causal inference. Third, comparative designs could improve inferential leverage by testing whether the negative effect of government distance on support for delegation intensifies when perceived alignment is more salient and accountability costs loom larger. Fourth, within-country heterogeneity deserves closer attention: multilevel models with party or region random slopes, and explicit tests of the distance effect within parties, would clarify whether the mechanism operated similarly among government supporters and among different strands of the opposition. Finally, linking attitudes to behavior—support for institutional reforms, willingness to cede authority in specific domains, or tolerance for curbing expert bodies—would shed light on the political consequences of ideologically valenced delegation.

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6 Appendix

6.1 Regression Models

Table A1: OLS Estimates: Technocracy and Business vs. Government Distance

	Tech: Seat-wt	Tech: Unwt	Tech: Closest	Biz: Seat-wt	Biz: Unwt	Biz: Closest
Constant	4.231***	4.357***	4.005***	4.055***	4.224***	3.649***
	(0.229)	(0.240)	(0.213)	(0.267)	(0.291)	(0.245)
Government distance (seat-weighted)	−0.663**			−1.850***		
	(0.216)			(0.219)		
Democratic satisfaction	−0.052*	−0.053*	−0.054*	−0.071**	−0.073**	−0.076**
	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.027)
Trust in politicians	−0.071**	−0.074**	−0.065*	−0.041	−0.044+	−0.033
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)
Government distance (unweighted)		−0.820***			−2.051***	
		(0.234)			(0.253)	
Government distance (closest-party)			−0.405*			−1.454***
			(0.200)			(0.202)
Num.Obs.	689	689	689	703	703	703
R2	0.057	0.061	0.050	0.151	0.152	0.126
R2 Adj.	0.038	0.042	0.030	0.133	0.134	0.108
RMSE	1.12	1.12	1.13	1.18	1.18	1.19
Std.Errors	Tech: Seat-wt	Tech: Unwt	Tech: Closest	Biz: Seat-wt	Biz: Unwt	Biz: Closest
Education FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: HC1 robust standard errors in parentheses. Models include education, age, gender, and region fixed effects (omitted for brevity).

6.2 Business Plots

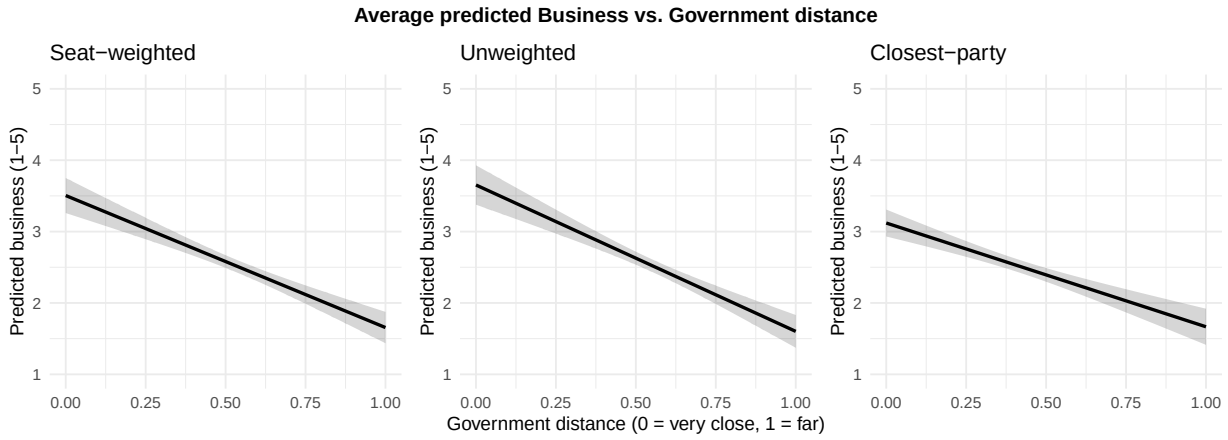

Figure A1: Average predicted, business vs. government distance (95% CIs).

6.3 Regression Table with Outcome Variable treated as Ordered

Table A2: Ordered logit (proportional odds) estimates: Technocracy and Business vs. Government Distance

	Tech (OL): Seat-wt	Tech (OL): Unwt	Tech (OL): Closest	Biz (OL): Seat-wt	Biz (OL): Unwt	Biz (OL): Closest
Government distance (seat-weighted)	−1.022**			−2.852***		
	(0.339)			(0.349)		
Democratic satisfaction	−0.084*	−0.085*	−0.087*	−0.113**	−0.116**	−0.116**
	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)
Trust in politicians	−0.107**	−0.113**	−0.096*	−0.063	−0.070+	−0.050
	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.038)
Government distance (unweighted)		−1.274***			−3.219***	
		(0.372)			(0.390)	
Government distance (closest-party)			−0.612*			−2.207***
			(0.311)			(0.318)
Num.Obs.	689	689	689	703	703	703
RMSE	3.18	3.18	3.18	2.65	2.65	2.65
Std.Errors	Tech (OL): Seat-wt	Tech (OL): Unwt	Tech (OL): Closest	Biz (OL): Seat-wt	Biz (OL): Unwt	Biz (OL): Closest
Education FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Model-based standard errors in parentheses. Cutpoints omitted. Models include education, age, gender, and region fixed effects (omitted for brevity).

6.4 Technocratic Support by Party Choice

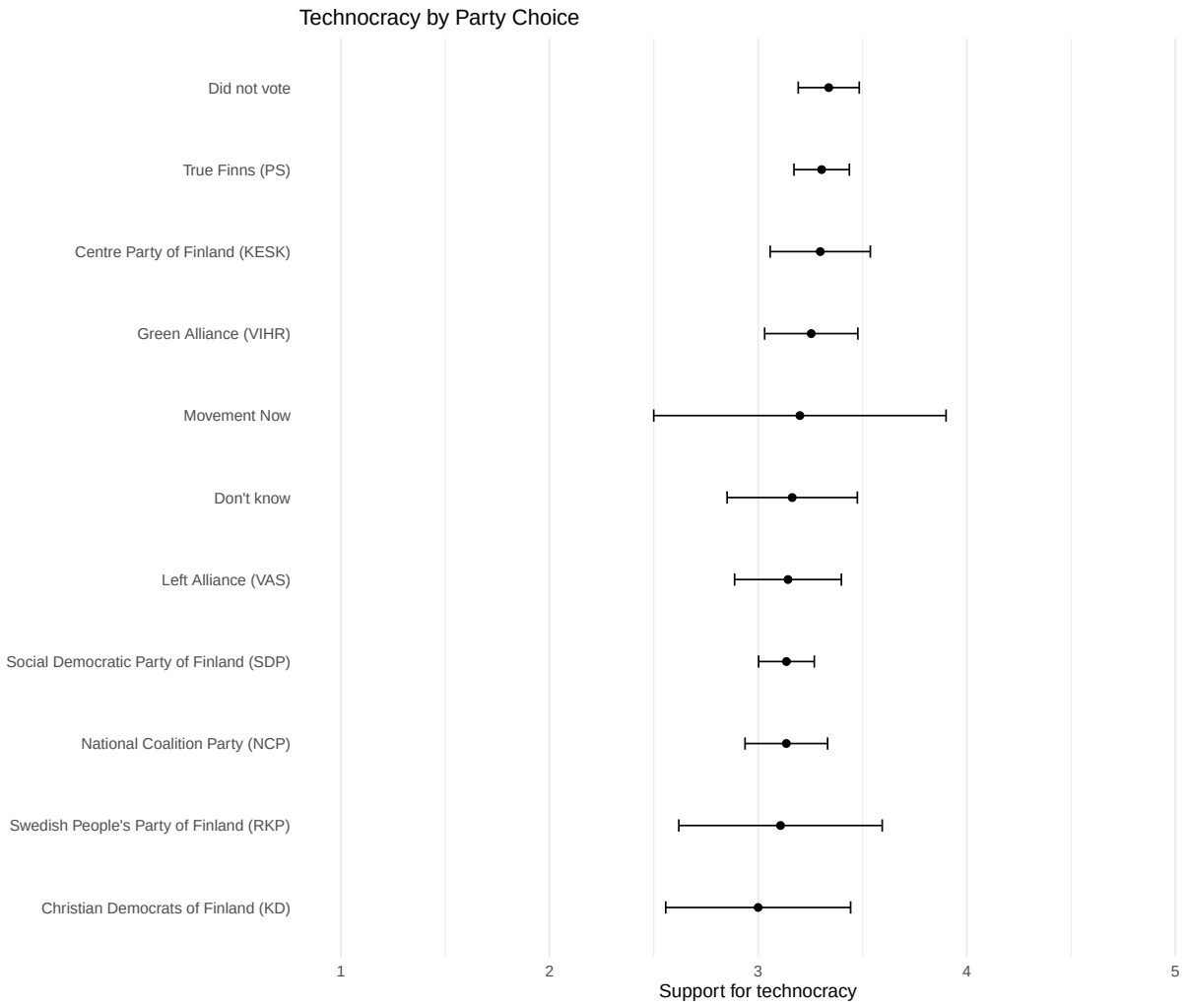

Figure A2: Technocracy by Party Choice (95% CIs).

6.5 Government-Expert Gap: Interactive Models

Table A3: Interactive OLS models: Technocracy × Government distance moderated by Gov-Expert trust gap

	Tech (OLS): Seat-wt	Tech (OLS): Unwt	Tech (OLS): Closest	Biz (OLS): Seat-wt	Biz (OLS): Unwt	Biz (OLS): Closest
(Intercept)	3.844***	3.921***	3.671***	4.157***	4.316***	3.881***
	(0.315)	(0.327)	(0.304)	(0.324)	(0.345)	(0.311)
Gov distance (seat–wt)	−0.718***			−1.708***		
	(0.235)			(0.244)		
Gov–Expert trust gap (centered)	2.764***	3.124***	2.273***	2.124**	2.440**	2.038**
	(0.853)	(0.893)	(0.697)	(1.011)	(1.111)	(0.823)
Overall trustfulness (centered)	−0.040*	−0.042*	−0.035	−0.022	−0.019	−0.017
	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.024)	(0.025)	(0.024)
Democratic satisfaction	−0.019	−0.020	−0.025	−0.069**	−0.074**	−0.077**
	(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.032)
Trust in politicians	−0.057	−0.057	−0.056	−0.068	−0.074*	−0.071*
	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.041)	(0.041)	(0.042)
genderMale	−0.042	−0.031	−0.028	0.168*	0.187*	0.189*
	(0.096)	(0.095)	(0.096)	(0.097)	(0.097)	(0.097)
Distance × Gap (seat–wt)	−4.513***			−1.523		
	(1.482)			(1.596)		
Gov distance (unwt)		−0.841***			−1.846***	
		(0.257)			(0.281)	
Distance × Gap (unwt)		−5.019***			−1.890	
		(1.567)			(1.776)	
Gov distance (closest)			−0.477**			−1.397***
			(0.220)			(0.220)
Distance × Gap (closest)			−4.371***			−1.378
			(1.424)			(1.526)
Num.Obs.	558	558	558	571	571	571
R2	0.096	0.099	0.088	0.184	0.183	0.169
RMSE	1.07	1.06	1.07	1.11	1.11	1.12